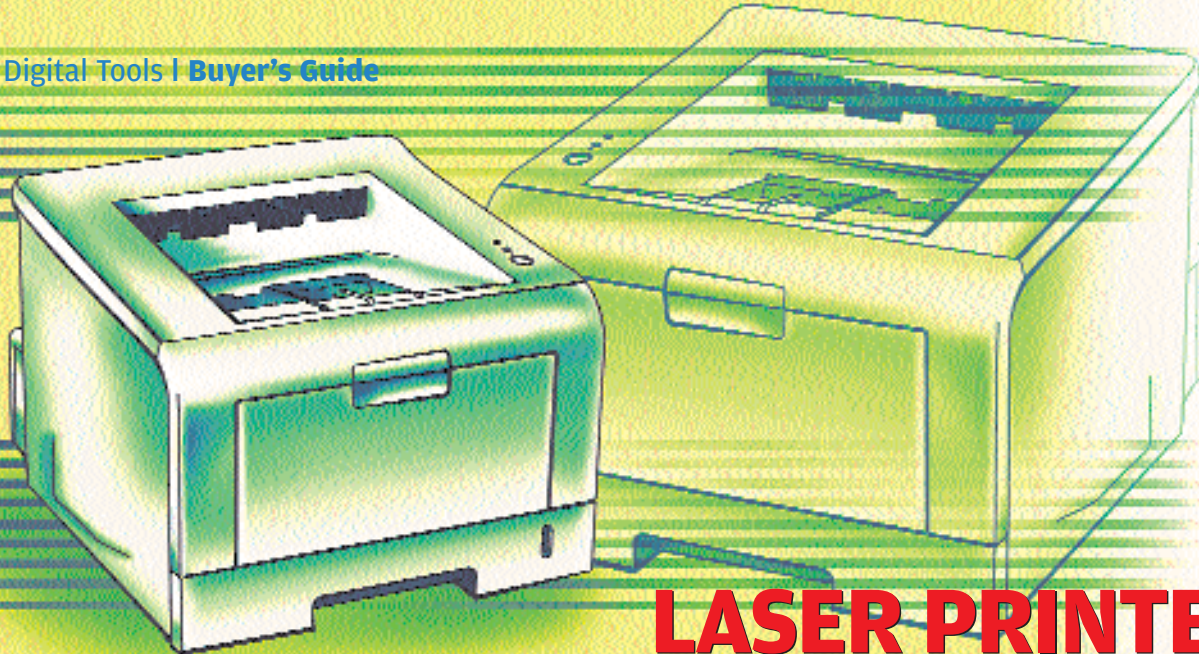




Prices of laser printers have fallen significantly over the past few months, but they are still more expensive than their inkjet counterparts. Laser printers have the advantage of speed and running costs over inkjets, but it is still a considerable initial investment.

The technology involved in printing is different in the two cases, therefore the nature of output and media type for printing will merit some consideration.

Consider your needs, features and specifications, the volume of usage and the content you need to print—after all, you're buying the printer to print!

Questions to ask the dealer

Can I test the printer?

You know what you need to print the

most, so take a typical document that you would print and test the printer's output before you lug it all the way to your home or office. If you like what you see, buy it; if you don't, remember that this is the output when it's new—it's only going to get worse with time.

What is the duty cycle for the bundled toner as well as a new toner?

The bundled toner normally has a lower duty cycle than a new toner. Also enquire about the cost of toner cartridges, as they vary between printer brands.

Is the printer network-ready?

Some printers are network-ready and can be directly connected to a LAN. Some printers offer optional networking capability, allowing you to add a network card later.

What interface and operating system support is available?

Almost all printers support USB 2.0, but you should check for additional connectivity options such as parallel and FireWire. Also check the operating systems supported by the manufacturer, and whether they provide the drivers for all supported OSes.



Points To Ponder

Does a laser printer suit my purpose?

Laser printers are fast and give crisp text and graph printing. They can print page after page with ease and accuracy. This suggests that laser printers are great for high-volume output with their high speed and low cost per page. If you are a photographer and your work involves printing on photographic sheets, stick to inkjet printing. If you are in a business that requires a large number of documents to be printed on a daily basis, laser printers would be a good choice.

What type of laser printer should I buy?

Mono and colour are the two basic types of laser printers. If your work involves more of B&W text, opt for a mono-laser printer.

What are the specifications for a laser printer?

Let us not discuss specs that are available on the leaflets of every printer. Let's look at those that are present in one printer and not in the other; the ones that make all the difference. **Automatic duplex printing** prints on both sides of the paper. You do not have to stand next to

it to flip the page. This saves a lot of time and also printing costs, as you can utilise both sides of a page.

Networking is a very important option for business and SoHo environments, where multiple users access the same printer. You can share the printer directly on the network and allow users to directly print on it!

It is good to have an **LCD display** on the printer; this helps you better interact with the printer. In some situations, the printer just doesn't act as you would like—this is when an LCD comes to the rescue and tells you that the printer is low on toner or that the paper is jammed!

If you are looking for a network printer, ensure that you have enough **memory buffer**. Sufficient memory buffer means speeding up of the printing process, because many users will access the printer simultaneously.

Although **size** is not as important as the above features, it does matter if your office is small and space is at a premium. Bigger devices handle more workload; so decide what is more important.

Interesting facts

The laser printer's roller pulls in a sheet of paper from the tray; the charged roller causes the paper to stick. The printing drum is given the opposite charge. A laser scans the surface of the drum and discharges it, leaving only those points that correspond to text and graphics charged. The charged toner particles on the drum stick to the oppositely charged paper. Finally, the fusing rollers heat the paper and melt the toner, permanently fusing it onto the paper's surface.

Usage tips

❑ Occasionally turn the printer Off to reduce the downtime and provide cooling time to the heating elements and laser.

❑ To share a printer on a network, attach it to a computer that acts as a server. Provide an alias and auto installation of drivers on the remote computer.

❑ Do not use special media such as iron-on transfer sheets and thin photo-quality paper—these may cause severe damage to the printer. ■